My First and Bestest Girlfriend

By Paul Feig

INTRODUCTION

I want to be perfectly clear up front . . . I have extensively researched this issue and nothing my mother told me is actually true!!

1. *It does NOT stunt your growth*
2. *It does NOT cause blindness.*
3. *It does NOT cause you to grow hair on your palms.*
4. *It will NOT drive a person crazy. . . and most importantly . . .*
5. *You CANNOT die from it.*

In fact, all the books say that it is perfectly healthy as long as it does not interfere with relationships with friends and family, or with doing other activities.

But at the time, at age 7, I didn't know anything!

My First and Bestest Girlfriend by Paul Feig.

(Pgs 54-65) I met my first real and true girlfriend when I was in the second grade. It turned out to be the beginning of a very long and faithful relationship.

We met in gym class. It was about a month into the new school year when our teacher, Mrs. Handler, informed us that we were going to learn how to climb ropes. Beneath the rope was an extra-thick mat, signaling to us all that severe injury was

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possible. Mrs. Handler, making it sound simple, informed us that we were to grab the rope and use our hands to propel ourselves upward. She said that as we climbed we should use our thighs to pinch the cord and hold ourselves in place. I watched as each of my friends, both boys and girls, scurried up the rope as if it were the easiest thing in the world. Maybe this wouldn't be so bad, I thought. However, nobody else in the class cried when they got a mosquito bite, either.

When my turn arrived, I approached the rope and awkwardly took it in my hands. The minute I touched that rope, I knew my success was going to depend strictly on how much strength I did or didn't have in my arms and legs. I've never had much upper-body strength, and at age seven I couldn't defeat a newborn baby in an arm-wrestling tournament.

"Just pull yourself up," Mrs. Handler said in an encouraging tone.

I looked up the rope and decided that if I could jump up and grab it, at least I'd be off the mat. I sprang up a few feet and gripped the rope. I immediately wrapped my legs around it and hung on. It felt like I had gotten myself pretty high up, but when I looked down, I saw that I was about one foot off the mat. I readjusted myself so that the rope was

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firmly pinched between my thighs and started to pull my body up. And to my amazement, I was actually getting up the rope.

And then something happened.

All of a sudden, I felt this strange wave coming over me, a powerful sensation that seemed to be building inside my body but I didn't know from where. It almost seemed to start in my chest and expand outward. I felt it in my butt, in my legs, in my arms . . . but especially in my pants. And the weird thing about it was that it felt good. Better than anything I'd ever felt in my life. The next thing I knew, the entire sensation rushed into my groin area and specifically into my-as the girls who lived next door to me used to call it- "thing." Boom boom boom. Was I having a heart attack? Was this what a stroke was?

"Paul? What are you doing up there? Are you stuck?" Mrs. Handler called up.

" . . . no . . . " was all I could muster.

"Well, either keep going or come back down. People are waiting."

"Uh, okay." The feeling was starting to subside and so I cautiously began to let myself down. As I slid slowly down the rope, it happened again. This time it hit harder and

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actually made me gasp. I froze again. Another wave of euphoric muscle contractions swept through my midsection. Boom boom boom.

"Paul, I don't know what you're doing but please hurry up."

I got to the bottom of the rope and put my feet on the mat. As I tried to walk away, I almost fell onto the gym floor. My legs felt like Jell-o.

A few hours later at recess, I decided to find out if I was the only one who'd experienced "the rope feeling." I asked my friend Brian if he'd felt anything during his climb.

"My hands really hurt after it" was all he offered up.

"Didn't you feel anything else? Anything that was really good?" I didn't want to get more detailed than that for fear that I would be informed of some life-ending disease that had as its main symptom "an intense, pleasurable sensation when climbing ropes in gym class."

Brian just shrugged at my question. "I didn't feel anything. What did it feel like?"

"I don't know," I said, trying to figure out how to verbalize it. "It was like I was floating or something. It felt really good."

"Huh. I don't know. Maybe you have cancer."

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That night, I was watching TV in my usual position, lying on my stomach with my chin on my hands and my legs bent at the knees behind me, my calves and feet slowly moving back and forth. Then something strange happened. The rope feeling started to come back again. I was very surprised and stunned. My brain was now beginning to overload with the joy I was experiencing at the return of my new best friend, "the rope feeling." As the sensation built, my father walked in the room.

"What are you watching?" he asked.

At that moment, I had no idea what I was watching. I was numb with intense feeling as the pounding returned. Boom boom boom.

" ... nothing ... " was all I could get out.

"Well, you shouldn't lie so close to the TV. You're gonna hurt your eyes. Move back."

It was as if the world were conspiring against me. I started to think that maybe what I was feeling was somehow forbidden and so God had sent my father in to put an end to it. But once again, I couldn't move.

"Okay, I'll move in a minute."

"Move *now,"* my dad said impatiently.

I slid myself back and the feeling immediately peaked. I

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gave a little gasp.

"What's the matter? Did you get a carpet burn?"

I couldn't summon the breath to speak and so just shook my head no.

Whereas bath time used to be an opportunity to make my G.I. Joe perform all sorts of underwater adventures in his Army Jack scuba gear, my time in the tub was now transformed into a quest for knowledge. Re-creation of "the rope feeling" apparently had something to do with pressure or contact between my private area and another surface and movement or friction between them. The bathtub became a virtual testing ground --Shampoo bottles, sponges, washcloths, soap bars, the side of the tub-yes, I'm afraid even GI. Joe was called into duty-but nothing seemed to work. However, as with all great inventors, a breakthrough occurs when one least expects it.

Somehow, through a coincidental sequence of washing with soap and scrubbing certain areas harder than normal, I stumbled across what appeared to be a winning combination. I had cracked the code and found that my discovery worked every single time I performed the same sequence of events. And trust me, I had just test-driven it. Many, many times.

I was now a seven-year-old Clark Kent, possessing an

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awe-inspiring secret that I would have to hide from the world. Superman never used his powers to rob banks and so I vowed that I would somehow find the strength to keep my new ability in check. But I knew it wouldn't be easy.

Wednesday arrived and I was reunited with my girlfriend, the rope. I was practically trembling with excitement and anticipation as I waited my turn to once again become one with my twenty-five-foot friend.

"Think you can make it all the way this time?" chuckled Mrs. Handler.

I nodded and headed up the rope. At first, nothing was happening. Then, at the ten-foot mark, I once again felt the stirrings that I had spent so much of the past week attempting to re-create. Another few pulls and the religious feeling returned. Boom boom boom.

I froze. Keep moving, I told myself. *But I can't, came another voice.* If I move, it'll stop. *It'll get better, I swear.* It's already about as good as I can handle. *That's what you think.*

Okay, okay, I thought. I'll do it. Muscles locked and tight, head spinning, throat clamped shut, I moved my hands up to pull. Unfortunately, my arms were Jell-o. My stomach suddenly seized into a cramp and my head and shoulders pitched backward. My legs flinched and contracted and the

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next thing I knew, I was plummeting downward. I heard a girl scream and Mrs. Handler yell "Stand back!" as I thudded heavily onto the mat.

"Maybe climbing the rope isn't your cup of tea, Paul," Mrs. Handler said sympathetically.

That afternoon on the playground, my friend Brian came over to me with urgent news. "Paul, I felt it! On the ropes today!"

"You did?" I wasn't sure if I was pleased or not. I had been leading myself to believe that I was the Chosen, that "the rope feeling" was mine and mine alone, something that Mother Nature had given me to make up for the fact that I was so goofy and girls didn't seem to really like me.

"Yeah. It was weird. It felt really good."

I stared at him for a second, thinking. Should I let him in on the fruits of my bathtub research? I leaned in close to him. "I figured out how to get that feeling without a rope," I said in the same way a guy in prison might tell a fellow inmate about a tunnel he'd been digging for years with a teaspoon. "You can do it in the bathtub."

Brian's eyes went wide and he immediately wanted to know everything. And so I filled him in. He sat, rapt, taking in every detail. I mentioned that shampoo bottles provided an interesting feeling because of the smoothness of their sides

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when used in conjunction with the soapy bathwater. By the time I finished, I could tell that he might feel that force of nature that makes you run, not walk, home from school and head straight for the bathtub.

The next day, I noticed Brian giving me dirty looks as we passed in the halls before school started. "Thanks a lot," he said angrily.

"Why? What happened?"

"I got my thing stuck in the shampoo bottle. My mom had to come in and take it off. She's really mad at me now."

"Why did you stick your thing *in* the bottle?"

"You told me to!"

"No, I didn't. I said to rub it on the side."

"Well, now my mom's making me read the Bible. She says she's even going to make me go to church camp." Brian looked at the ground and shook his head.

Oh, well. At least he didn't tell his mom that I was the one who'd told him how to do it. Brian stood up and started to walk away. . . . "And my mom said I'm not allowed to hang out with you anymore. And she says she wants your phone number so she can call your parents."

Hello, church camp.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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